

took out a second loan. My wife worked in downtown Pittsburgh. She drove to a Park & Ride, where her car sat idle all day. From there, she rode a bus into the city, requiring a monthly bus pass. My job required driving the opposite direction to get to work. Her commute was about forty minutes each way, while mine was closer to fifty. Because we were young and just getting established in our careers, we worked long hours. With work, our commutes, and a three-bedroom house with a yard and a pool to maintain, the last thing we wanted to do was to cook. So we ate out five to six nights a week. We also went out for lunch frequently. It was easier than finding time to prepare meals.

We found ourselves working non-stop to pay for a house we couldn't enjoy, cars that were losing value while being used primarily for getting us to and from work, and unhealthy restaurant meals we ate because we didn't have time to shop and cook for ourselves. Our existence was a textbook example of being stuck on the hamster wheel that many people keep spinning their entire lives.

After a little over a year of this, we sold our house and moved back to our hometown where the cost of living was lower. We rented a small house for three years and were able to reduce our time commuting significantly. During that time, we saved my entire salary